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Tea App

Survey Link: https://qualtricsxm9lhb9thf.qualtrics.com/jfe/form/SV_1WZHjTxQKeStlfc

Introduction

Navigating the modern dating scene increasingly means navigating digital risk, where apps designed to support communication and connection can also introduce fears about privacy breaches, misinformation, and unwanted exposure. The Tea App is a clear example of this complicated landscape because it encourages women to share experiences about men they are dating or have dated in order to promote community safety, warn others, or highlight positive interactions. What began as a space for empowerment and mutual protection has quickly become the subject of ethical, social, and political debate, largely because of concerns about doxxing, unverified claims, misuse of personal data, and the potential for harm. Over time, the practice of sharing information about partners has shifted from private group chats and informal social posts into a large, searchable public platform with more than eleven million women participating. This transition has raised new questions about what counts as necessary safety information and what crosses into intentional harm, especially after the Tea App experienced a major data leak involving driver's licenses, personal identifying information, and user details that damaged public trust. At the same time, some users report engaging with the app purely for entertainment, which includes sharing exaggerated or humorous profiles and even fictional or symbolic entries such as posts about campus mascots. These patterns show how easily the line between genuine

safety concerns and casual entertainment can blur in digital spaces. Current laws do not offer clear guidance for how platforms like Tea should operate because United States privacy regulations leave significant gaps related to anonymous submissions, the sharing of photos without consent, unverified content, and the posting of criminal records. Section 230 shields platforms from liability for what users post, which places responsibility for accuracy and ethics on the individuals contributing information. Survey questions that ask how bothered people would be to see themselves posted neutrally, positively, or negatively without their knowledge reveal how unsettled users feel about the lack of boundaries. Questions about anonymity options, notification policies, and motivations for posting highlight the extent to which people are unsure about what is ethical or acceptable. Three key stakeholder groups shape this issue. Women using the app want safety and accountability while still protecting their own privacy. Men posted on the app face reputational, emotional, and sometimes professional consequences whether the information about them is accurate or not. Developers and privacy regulators hold the power to define verification practices, moderation systems, background checks, and the boundary between public safety and intentional doxxing. Understanding how these groups perceive the Tea App is essential for evaluating both the risks and the potential benefits of a platform that can provide protection yet also cause harm.

2. Methodology

Our team collected our data from online forums, due to their straightforward formatting and robust comment sorting modes. In order to find relevant forum threads, our team searched for discussions of the tea app, and the tea app data breach using Google to search for reddit threads specifically. Using a search engine for efficient data collection allows for more time to be spent developing and deploying our later user survey, but also introduces an algorithmic bias to

our data. Because the data our team was able to collect was influenced by Google's search algorithm, we took steps to limit any algorithmic biases introduced to our dataset. We collected twenty comments per team member, only collecting 2-3 comments per forum thread in order to gather data from a larger demographic. Within each thread, we selected different comment sort orders, and collected comments at random.

Once the dataset had been compiled, our manual coding process began, starting with identifying the stakeholders present in the context of each comment. Our team identified three major stakeholders present in the dataset: Users, developers, and corporations. With these three stakeholders in mind, we then generated an initial theme for each of the comments. The initial themes generated were then condensed into a smaller group of themes for consistency, and used as the primary theme group. Using the condensed theme group, we then applied secondary and tertiary themes for each of the comments, with a final round of review for accuracy.

Our team then utilized AI-assisted analysis to further analyse the sentiment themes of the compiled and cleaned dataset. The entire coded database was uploaded to chatGPT, and it was given the following prompt: "use this data from reddit and similar online forums and create a set of themes using traditional thematic analysis." Using our codebook, chatGPT generated a theme table (appendix A, fig. 1) and flow chart (appendix A, fig. 1). The table consists of three major themes and descriptions of their criteria, with 2-3 subthemes listed for each theme. The flowchart is a visual representation of the themes and their subthemes, concisely breaking down each theme and their components. Using these new resources, we compared the major themes and subthemes generated by AI with our existing codebook to develop and analyze our survey.

Using a generative AI to develop further themes and components added depth to our team's analysis of the dataset, but likely introduced bias due to the way that large language

models are trained on huge datasets. This specific use case was ideal for reducing bias, because much of the data used to train chatGPT comes from online forums like Reddit (Staff, 2024). However, the bias introduced using this methodology for coding data is non-zero, and may not be as effective depending on the data's source.

Survey Analysis

In order to create our survey, our team examined the coded dataset, as well as the AI-generated supplemental themes. Using these artifacts allowed our team to develop a survey focused on gathering further information around the themes our team identified. Data privacy was the dominant theme found in the dataset, and so we developed our survey questions accordingly. The survey was built and distributed using Qualtrics, and was distributed to classmates, as well as through the team's personal social channels. The deployed survey included questions gathering data about age, gender, data privacy, doxxing, safety, and entertainment.

The majority of respondents were open to the idea of notifying men who are posted about on the Tea app, as analysis showed that ~39% of respondents thought that men should be notified of posts about them, while ~43% would consider such a policy, and ~18% of respondents thought that men should not be notified (appendix B, fig. 1). In a similar manner, the majority of respondents reported that they would be bothered by a negative anonymous post about themselves (appendix B, fig.2). When cross-analyzing survey responses regarding whether or not men should be notified of their presence on the Tea app with responses regarding the importance of anonymity, we found that 50% of respondents who reported anonymity as being important to them felt that men should be notified, while the other 50% felt that they should not (appendix B, fig.3). This survey data and analysis shows that while respondents found anonymity to be important, the implementation of policy affecting anonymity was divisive, and our policy design

should respect the existing anonymity, while simultaneously cutting down on false negative posts.

Ethical Analysis

The central ethical dilemma surrounding the Tea App concerns the tension between community safety for women and the potential for harmful doxxing, misinformation, and unjustified reputational damage to the men who appear on the platform. To understand this conflict more fully, we examined the issue through three ethical lenses: utilitarianism, deontology, and virtue ethics. Each framework highlights different concerns about how people use the Tea App, what responsibilities the platform has to its users, and how society should balance the need for safety with the need for fairness and respect for privacy.

Utilitarianism evaluates the Tea App based on the consequences it creates and whether those outcomes maximize overall well-being. From a utilitarian perspective, the app has potential benefits. Women can warn each other about individuals who pose real threats, share experiences that help others make safer decisions, and create informal networks of support. Our own experiences and data showed that the app can prevent harm by allowing women to avoid men with documented histories of violence or manipulation. However, the harms are also significant. Unverified posts can damage reputations, spread misinformation, and encourage retaliatory behavior from men who feel targeted. The entertainment-oriented use of the platform increases the risk of false reports and exaggerations, which can harm innocent people without producing any social benefit. A utilitarian would argue that the app must reduce these harms through stronger verification, clearer boundaries, or redesigned features. If the app cannot minimize

widespread negative consequences, then the overall good it produces does not outweigh the harm.

Deontology focuses on duties, rights, and moral rules rather than outcomes. This framework raises direct concerns about the Tea App because it deals with posting content about others without their consent, exposing personal information, and potentially violating the rights of individuals to privacy and dignity. Even when users believe they are acting to protect others, deontology emphasizes that the manner in which they act still matters. The app encourages behavior that can easily cross moral boundaries, such as revealing identifying information, posting photos without permission, or spreading unverified claims. The platform itself has a duty to respect user privacy and uphold clear principles about consent and fairness. When the Tea App experienced a data leak that exposed driver's licenses and personal information, it violated this duty. Deontological reasoning suggests that an ethical platform must protect the rights of all people involved, not only women using the app but also the individuals they post about. Any system that encourages or allows violations of privacy, even for good intentions, becomes ethically unstable under this view.

Virtue ethics evaluates the Tea App by considering the character traits and habits it encourages among its users. Ideally, a community safety platform would promote honesty, responsibility, courage, and mutual care. In practice, Tea often encourages habits of gossip, impulsive posting, and entertainment-driven participation. The design of the app, including its name and flagging system, conditions users to think quickly rather than thoughtfully, and to treat complex interpersonal issues as content for public consumption. While many women use the app with good intentions, the structure reinforces behaviors that lack empathy or fairness. Men who appear on the app may respond with anger or fear, which increases the risk of harmful retaliation

and weakens the sense of mutual respect that virtue ethics values. A virtuous approach to safety would require more accountability, more reflection, and a platform environment that encourages thoughtful and accurate reporting instead of casual posting.

After comparing these frameworks, our group found that a combination of utilitarianism and deontology was the most useful for forming a position. Utilitarianism helped us understand the real-world consequences of the Tea App and why many women rely on it despite its flaws. Deontology reminded us that the rights of individuals cannot be ignored, even in the pursuit of safety. Together, these frameworks helped clarify why the Tea App's current design is ethically inconsistent. It produces benefits for some users but does so through practices that violate basic duties to privacy and accuracy. Virtue ethics reinforced this conclusion by showing how the app's culture encourages harmful habits rather than moral responsibility. This combination of insights shaped our group's position and informed the policy recommendation that comes next.

4. Policy Recommendation

From our research on the Tea App, we identified several gaps in the current state of women's safety and community applications, as well as many ethical concerns with the Tea App. In particular, we noticed that a huge portion of *why* the Tea App exists is to provide a safe and unavailable to outsiders community for women to talk safely with each other. Women crave spaces where they can communicate with each other honestly without fear of violence or retaliation from the men in their lives that they are reporting on or discussing. The Tea App aims to solve this problem, but cannot do a perfect job. Many men are active members on the Tea App, some of them using the IDs of other people to gain access.

Another failure from the Tea App that we noticed was a lack of regulation and rules surrounding how the application is allowed to be used. It *can* be used for safety, and we even experienced the safety of it firsthand. Two of our team members recognized an individual who had been individually dangerous to them and their friends. Despite the safety aspect of this, the ‘flag’ functionality, which allows users to mark red or green flags on individual men without any reasoning promotes uninformed reports and can highlight inaccuracies. This can lead to the doxxing and malintention part of the Tea App. Similarly, even calling the app ‘Tea’ promotes the ideology of gossiping and spreading negativity. It doesn’t exactly promote accurate reporting or thoughtful insight for other women.

From our data analysis, this doxxing and mistrust in Tea is what promotes the fear of the application within men. They are fearful of being posted inaccurately and having opportunities hindered for them, whether those are dating, career, or family-related. While a trustworthy and good man shouldn’t worry about what is posted about him, this gossip and entertainment side of Tea is what makes it ethically concerning. It can also contribute to violent reactions from men and further endanger women (even though men weren’t supposed to use it in the first place).

Our policy proposal for a competing application that aims to promote the safety and community of Tea while removing the doxxing capability is an application that relies on publicly available information and reporting for accuracy. Instead of having users add individuals to the database, our new application will be location-based and rely on the databases of local sex offender and crime registrations. From these databases, individuals can see a map of local sex offenders and criminals and contribute to information about these people. For example, a person can view listed individuals, select ‘I know this person,’ and they can become open for private messaging from other users. This allows for women to be safe and communicative about people

in the area without publicly endangering themselves or doxxing others. Similarly, women will be able to submit inquiries into individuals to local police departments if they have concerns about specific individuals in their area. This opens low-key resources for women to submit information and get help they need without endangering themselves.

Of course, some problems with this policy are the potential for missing information or individuals. What if someone is dangerous to women without having any formal legal repercussions? This is something that toes the line between being in the interest of public safety without opening the floodgates for doxxing or inaccurate information. Furthermore, the reporting feature could open up the local police departments with false allegations or individual biases ultimately wasting their time. For example, this could be misused to report people and affirm individual prejudices, much like the racist predictive policing models.

5. Reflection & Divergence

From our discussions as a team and our group coding, all of us came to believe that the Tea application was a very solid idea with a real world need for the security and safety of women in the community. We all had a large deontological perspective on the idea of posting about other people, it isn't a morally right thing to do and in that way the Tea app needs to adjust the interactivity so that people can't post about each other without their knowledge. Elizabeth's main ideology was that if Tea's UI was going to stay the same, both people should be required to be aware of the posting going on. Ely's main concern was the data privacy of the Tea application and the overarching problems with having addresses and drivers' licenses leaked publicly. Averie had more of a perspective that the gossip portion of tea should be removed entirely because that is what is making it a negative and violent approach for some people.

As we developed our policy recommendation, the main divergence we faced was whether or not to continue to allow the same discussion that Tea had for women. Some of us felt like that was the inherent point of the application, but others were more concerned with the potential harm posting publicly opens up for users. In the end, we decided to go with a private discussion feature that removes the public shaming aspect of Tea but maintains the community discussion opportunity for women.

6. Future Directions

From our research, a lot of questions emerged about the safety of semi publicly available resources like the Tea app. How often are people facing violent interactions because of something true and accurate they posted online about another person? How can women ever safely interact online without the threat of real life violence or repercussion? Is that fair to desire? There are many unresolved tensions with the Tea Application, but the majority of them are being remedied as the application was removed from the App Store in October 2025 for failure to meet Apple's data privacy regulations. In the future, policymakers should research the legality of posting about other people without consent and seek to make a clear set of regulations for cases like the Tea app. Furthermore, researchers and designers should consider new ways to create online spaces for women and other targeted groups to discuss without fear of violence. Beyond the classroom, this project could expand into the realm of safety applications like CU Boulder Safe, which contains a mobile blue light and safety resources for CU students, faculty, and staff. Having a sex offender registry and inquiry easily accessible on that resource could be very useful for every user.

Appendix A:

Final codebook:

<https://docs.google.com/spreadsheets/d/1rc1piOjjZx8NnllKfXjt-D0rUkEh4RcDt4pyQO8dxoQ/edit?usp=sharing>

AI Overarching Themes:

 THEME TABLE

Theme	Description	Subthemes / Components
1. Perceived Harms	Users describe feeling vulnerable to negative impacts created or amplified by the Tea App.	Reputation Damage, Privacy Erosion, Community-Amplified Harm
2. Distrust & Skepticism	Users question the intentions, credibility, and governance of the app and similar platforms.	Safety vs Surveillance, Distrust in Platforms
3. Cultural Behaviors	Users highlight how online communities use the app for gossip, entertainment, and collective behavior that may escalate harm.	Entertainment/Gossip Culture, Community Dynamics

Figure 1

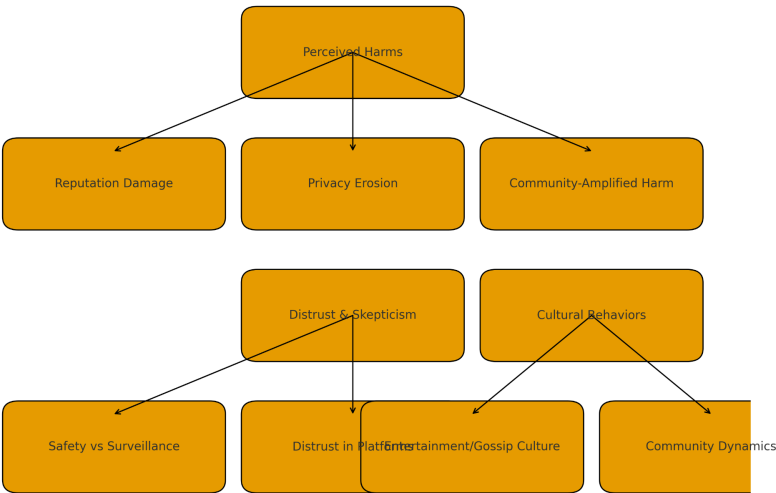


Figure 2

Appendix B:

Should Men Be Notified if They are Listed?

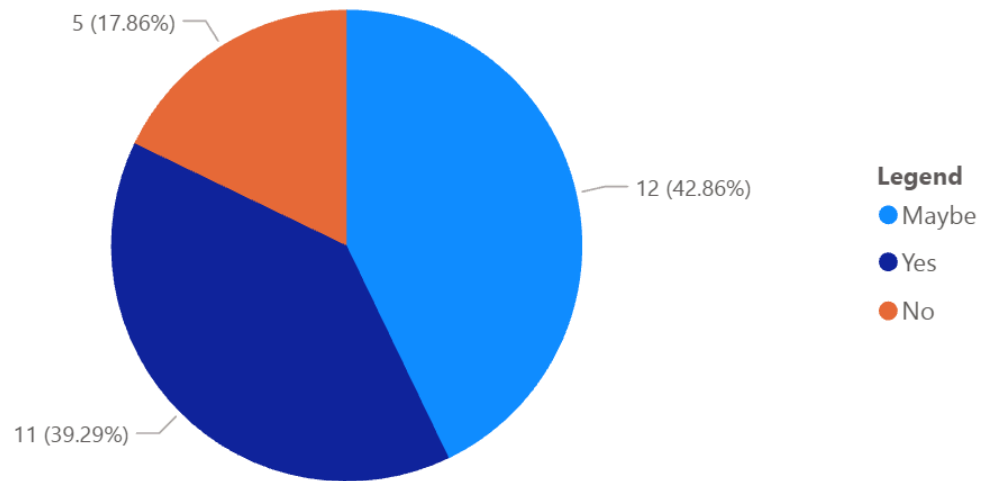


Figure 1

How Bothered Would You be by a Negative Post About Yourself?

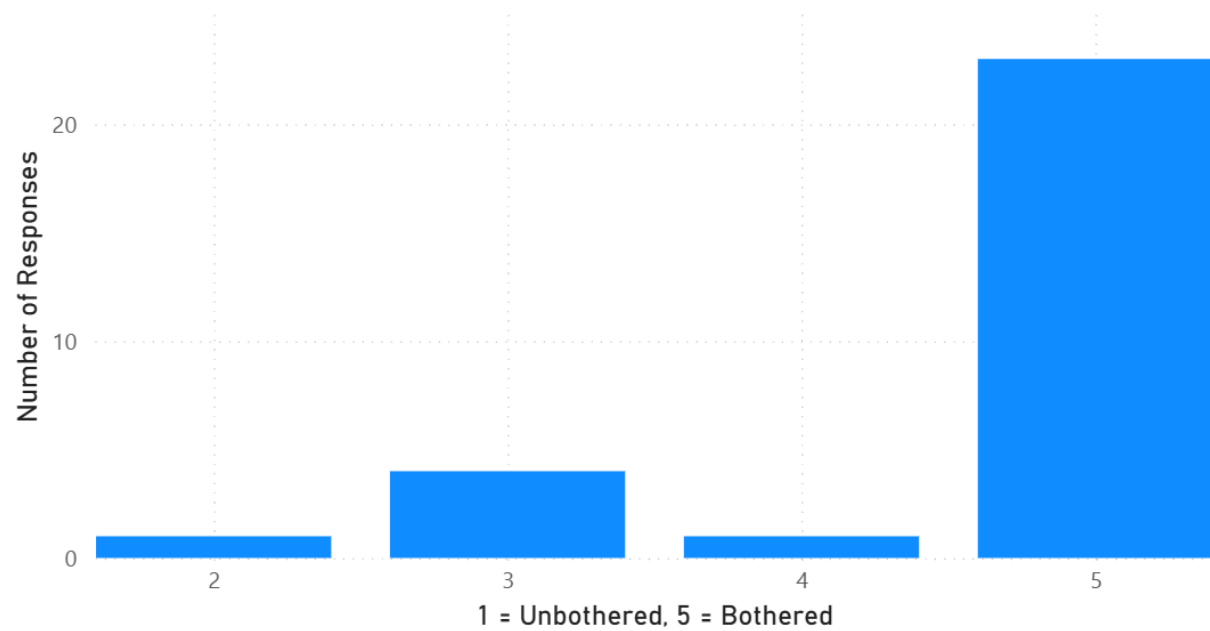


Figure 2

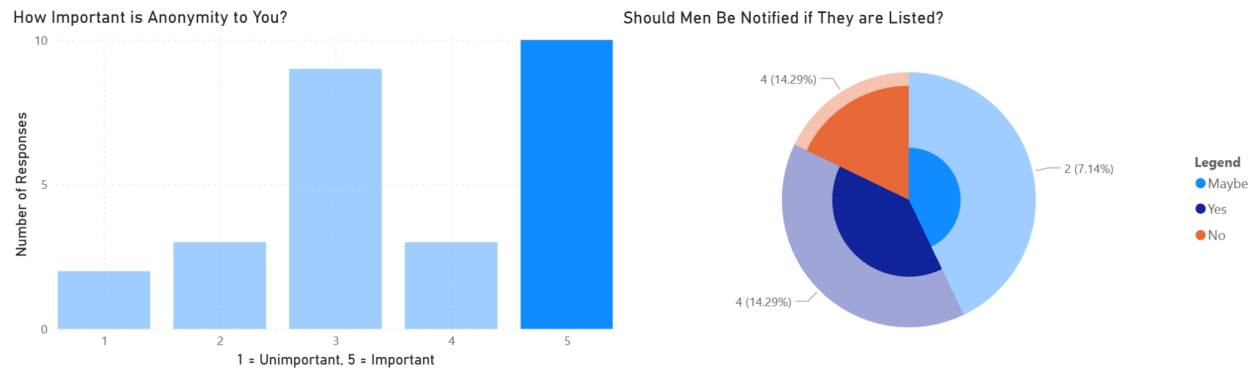


Figure 3

Appendix C: Survey data

<https://drive.google.com/file/d/17jkwwZccG8zCx82BUXGnA6gDow53up7q/view?usp=sharing>

Appendix D: Annotated bibliography and/or media sources

Staff. (2024, September 25). *Reddit and OpenAI Build Partnership*. Upvoted.

<https://redditinc.com/news/reddit-and-oai-partner>

